

National Flood Insurance Program

FLOOD INSURANCE MANUAL

October 2025



FEMA



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Message to National Flood Insurance Program Agents and Insurers

The National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) is committed to enhancing the customer experience. However, we cannot do it alone. In partnership with the Write Your Own (WYO) insurance companies, NFIP Direct, insurance company vendors, and agents, we continue to improve our policyholders' experience.

Our commitment to improving the customer experience includes making our NFIP products and processes less complex and more understandable for all agents, insurers, and policyholders.

That is why we regularly update our claims and underwriting manuals in plain language so insurance professionals can provide policyholders with consistent and reliable service. We recognize the task of protecting Americans against the devastating impacts of flooding is challenging. Flooding remains the country's number one natural hazard. Despite the ever-growing threat, flooding remains an under-appreciated risk. We are doing all we can to provide the tools and resources to help educate our stakeholders about the serious effects of flooding.

As agents, you are critical in helping the NFIP close the flood insurance gap. Agents and insurance professionals are at the forefront of helping policyholders understand the importance of making sure they have the right coverage and renewing their policy on time. In order to be successful in closing the flood insurance gap, it takes the entire insurance community. FEMA depends on your continued expertise and commitment to help our policyholders protect the lives they've built, recover more quickly from flooding events, and reduce disaster suffering.

I recognize the hard work that you do every day and appreciate that you continue to treat our policyholders with integrity and respect. We cannot deliver this important program without you.

Together, we can close the flood insurance gap and reduce disaster suffering one policy at a time.

Sincerely,

Elizabeth Asche, Ph.D.

Assistant Administrator, Federal Insurance



1. Introduction

I. Purpose and Audience

The National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) *Flood Insurance Manual* provides NFIP underwriting policies and processes to enable effective and consistent program implementation. The primary audience of the manual is NFIP agents and insurers. It covers every aspect of selling and servicing NFIP flood insurance policies. **All premiums, fees, surcharges and assessments paid for a Standard Flood Insurance Policy become U.S. Treasury funds as soon as they are paid.**¹

II. NFIP Program and Operational Model

A. Program Overview

Flooding has long been the nation's most costly natural disaster. In the face of mounting flood losses and escalating disaster relief costs to the general taxpayers, Congress enacted the National Flood Insurance Act of 1968.

The NFIP is a federal program enabling property owners in participating communities to purchase insurance protection against losses from flooding. The Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), which administers the NFIP, makes federal flood insurance available to residents in local communities that adopt and enforce floodplain management ordinances intended to reduce future flood damage. FEMA also provides certain properties with discounted premiums to encourage community and property owner participation.

B. NFIP Operational Model

Policyholders purchase NFIP flood insurance through licensed insurance agents who write with participating private insurance companies or directly with the NFIP through its servicing agent.

Under the Write Your Own (WYO) Program, private insurance companies (known as WYO companies) enter into an agreement with FEMA to sell NFIP policies next to their own insurance lines and adjust and pay claims arising under the NFIP policies. WYO companies are responsible for all aspects of servicing the policies they sell, including issuing, endorsing, underwriting, renewing, and canceling policies. WYO companies may withhold from written premiums administrative and operating expenses for selling and servicing NFIP policies. WYO companies must align their flood business with their normal business practices for their other insurance lines, subject to applicable legal and administrative requirements.

In addition to the WYO Program, FEMA directly sells and services NFIP policies through a contracted direct servicing agent, known as the NFIP Direct. Any prospective policyholder may seek coverage through NFIP Direct. NFIP Direct is also the sole entity servicing Group Flood Insurance Policies (GFIPs) and selling and servicing NFIP policies insuring buildings that have experienced severe repetitive losses.

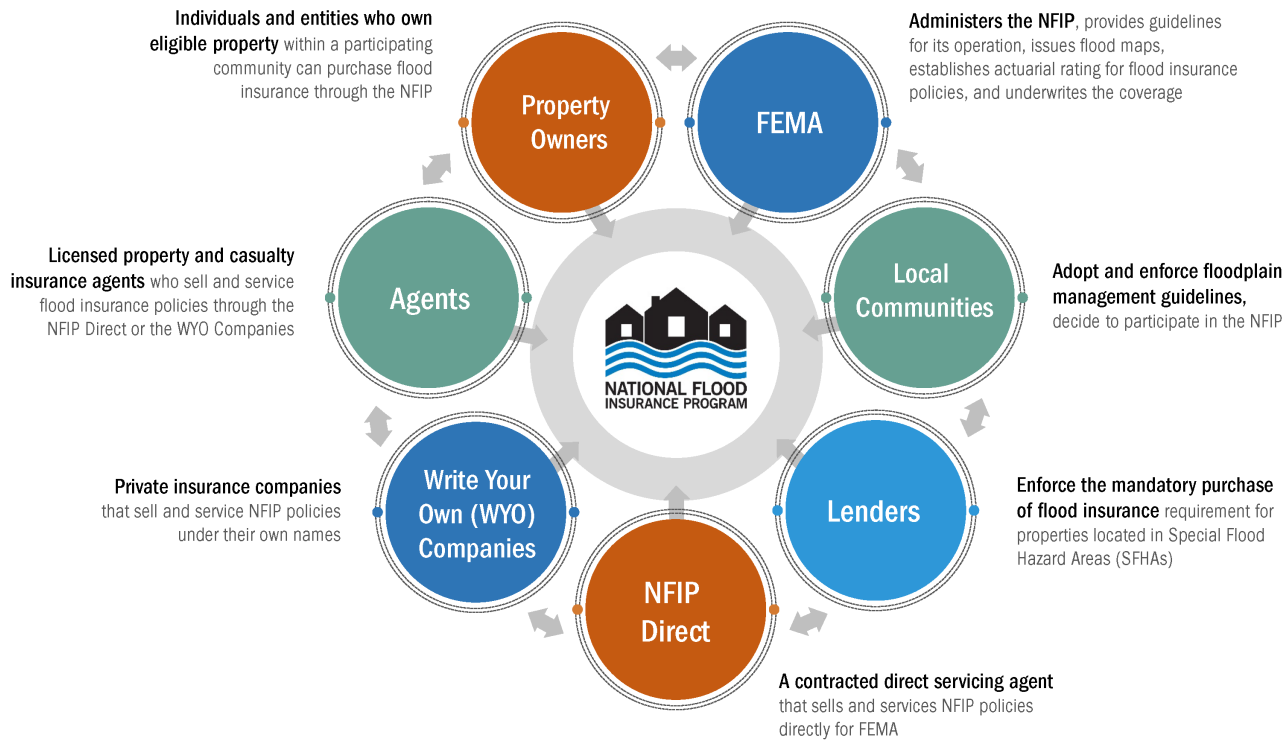
Whether written with a WYO company or the NFIP Direct, all NFIP policies (with the exception of GFIPs) are subject to the same policies, rating methodology, and processes stated in the *NFIP Flood Insurance Manual*.

More broadly, the NFIP involves effective partnership between the Federal Government; the property and casualty insurance industry; state, local, tribal, and territorial governments; lending institutions; and property owners. **Figure 1** below shows how each partner helps to implement the program.

Note: As used in the *NFIP Flood Insurance Manual*, the term FEMA typically includes the agency and its contractors.

1. See 42.U.S.C 4017

Figure 1. NFIP Partners



C. Legislative Reforms

In the more than 50 years since passage of the National Flood Insurance Act of 1968, Congress has enacted legislation seeking to improve the NFIP, as summarized in **Table 1**. Of special note is the Flood Disaster Protection Act of 1973, which mandated the purchase of flood insurance for certain properties in high flood-risk areas of NFIP-participating communities. This mandatory purchase requirement expanded the overall number of insured properties, including those that qualified for discounted premiums.

Table 1. Major NFIP Reform Legislation

ACT	PROVISIONS
Flood Disaster Protection Act of 1973 (FDPA)	Established the flood insurance mandatory purchase requirement: - Prohibited federally backed lenders from making loans secured by buildings located in a Special Flood Hazard Area (SFHA), unless the building is covered by flood insurance. - Prohibited federal assistance for the acquisition or construction of structures located in an SFHA, unless the community is participating in the NFIP (unless the assistance is related to disaster assistance provided during a non-flood event). - Prohibited federal assistance for the acquisition or construction of a structure located in an SFHA unless the structure is covered by flood insurance.

Table 1. Major NFIP Reform Legislation *continued*

ACT	PROVISIONS
National Flood Insurance Reform Act of 1994²	- Expanded and strengthened the FDPA's mandatory purchase requirement. - Required FEMA to offer insurance covering the cost of complying with state and local floodplain management ordinances, referred to as Increased Cost of Compliance (ICC) coverage. - Established a grant program to fund activities designed to reduce the risk of flood damage to structures covered by an NFIP policy (referred to as the Flood Mitigation Assistance (FMA)) Program. - Required a mandatory 30-day waiting period before a new NFIP policy becomes effective.
Bunning-Bereuter-Blumenauer Flood Insurance Reform Act of 2004³	- Required FEMA to create a process to enable policyholders to appeal claims decisions. - Required FEMA to provide enhanced disclosure to policyholders explaining policy coverages and other terms.
Biggert-Waters Flood Insurance Reform Act of 2012 (BW-12)⁴	- Required FEMA to phase out premium discounts on an accelerated time frame. - Required establishment of a National Flood Insurance Reserve Fund to be available to pay claims, repay debt owed to the U.S. Treasury, and meet the future obligations of the NFIP. - Increased and adjusted the annual premium increase caps.
Homeowner Flood Insurance Affordability Act of 2014 (HFIAA)⁵	- Repealed and limited many premium increases required by BW-12. - Imposed a surcharge based on occupancy and primary residence status (referred to as the HFIAA surcharge). - With limited exceptions, reduced the cap on annual increases for flood insurance premiums to 18 percent. - Authorized FEMA to secure reinsurance for the NFIP from the traditional reinsurance and capital markets.

III. Organization of the Document

The *NFIP Flood Insurance Manual* is divided into six main sections and several appendices, as shown in **Table 2**. Table 2 provides the overall organization of the *NFIP Flood Insurance Manual* and briefly describes the content in each section.

2. National Flood Insurance Reform Act of 1994, Pub. L. No. 103-325, Title V, 108 Stat. 2255; 42 U.S.C. 4001 et seq.

3. Bunning-Bereuter-Blumenauer Flood Insurance Reform Act of 2004, Pub. L. No. 108-264, 118 Stat. 712; 42 U.S.C. 4001 et seq.

4. Biggert-Waters Flood Insurance Reform Act of 2012, Pub. L. No. 112-141, Div. F, Title II, Subtitle A, 126 Stat. 916; 42 U.S.C. 4001 et seq.

5. Homeowner Flood Insurance Affordability Act of 2014, Pub. L. No. 113-89, 128 Stat. 1020; 42 U.S.C. 4001 et seq.

Table 2. Organization of the NFIP Flood Insurance Manual

TITLE	DESCRIPTION	HIGH-LEVEL CONTENT
Section 1: Introduction	Overview of the NFIP, its operational model, and resources for agents, insurers, and other stakeholders	I. Purpose and Audience II. NFIP Program and Operational Model III. Document Organization IV. NFIP Resources
Section 2: Before You Start	Information needed before writing a NFIP flood insurance policy	I. Policy Forms II. Eligibility for NFIP Coverage III. Effective Dates for New Policies and Endorsements IV. Administrative Topics V. Assignment and Transfer of Business VI. Reformation Due to Insufficient Premium or Rating Information
Section 3: How to Write	Description of the information needed to rate a policy and applicable rating rules	I. Introduction II. General Rating Information III. Condominium Rating Information IV. Provisional Rating Information
Section 4: How to Endorse	Guidance on changing or correcting information on an existing NFIP flood insurance policy	I. Endorsement Process II. Coverage and Deductible Changes III. Other Premium-Bearing Changes IV. Assignment of a Policy
Section 5: How to Renew	Guidance and information on how to renew an existing NFIP flood insurance policy	I. General Information II. Renewal Process III. Additional Information
Section 6: How to Cancel	Guidance on valid cancellation/nullification reason codes and associated effective date and refund rules	I. General Information II. Valid Cancellation Reason Codes III. Processing a Cancellation or Nullification Request
Appendix A: Standard Flood Insurance Policy	The three Standard Flood Insurance Policy (SFIP) forms stating definitions, coverages, limitations, and exclusions for NFIP flood insurance policies, including terms and conditions unique to the NFIP	I. Dwelling Form II. General Property Form III. Residential Condominium Building Association Policy Form
Appendix B: Forms	Forms that collect the information needed to rate a NFIP flood insurance policy and process certain policy transactions	I. NFIP Flood Insurance Application Form II. NFIP Flood Insurance General Change Endorsement Form III. NFIP Flood Insurance Cancellation/Nullification Request IV. NFIP Residential Basement Floodproofing Certificate V. NFIP Floodproofing Certificate for Non-Residential Structures VI. NFIP Elevation Certificate and Instructions

Table 2. Organization of the *NFIP Flood Insurance Manual* continued

TITLE	DESCRIPTION	HIGH-LEVEL CONTENT
Appendix C: Quick Start Guide to Writing a Policy	A step-by-step reference guide on how to write a new NFIP flood insurance policy using the NFIP Flood Insurance Application Form	I. Agency Number/Agent Number II. Property Address III. Building Occupancy, Policy Form, and Coverage Amounts IV. Building Description V. Foundation Type VI. Proper Flood Openings VII. First Floor Height Determination VIII. Building Characteristics
Appendix D: Flood Maps	General information about NFIP flood maps and flood zones	I. Flood Map Service Center II. Flood Hazard Maps III. Map Zones IV. Locating a Property on a Map V. Changing or Correcting a Flood Map by a Letter of Map Change (LOMC)
Appendix E: Coastal Barrier Resources System	Guidance on eligibility for NFIP coverage under the Coastal Barrier Resources System	I. General Information II. Determining Eligibility
Appendix F: Severe Repetitive Loss Properties	Information on procedures unique to servicing policies for Severe Repetitive Loss (SRL) properties	I. General Information II. New Business III. Notification Requirements IV. Underwriting Requirements V. Process for Correcting or Updating a Property's SRL Status VI. Flood Mitigation Assistance (FMA) Program VII. Pivot Identification and Notification Process
Appendix G: Leased Federal Properties	Information on procedures unique to writing and servicing policies for leased federal properties	I. General Information II. Requirements III. Correcting an LFP Designation
Appendix H: Claims	General information on claims processing	I. Information for Policyholders after a Flood II. Claim Process III. Disputed Claims IV. Appealing a Claim V. Litigation VI. Increased Cost of Compliance (ICC) Claims
Appendix I: Policyholder Communications	Sample documents referenced in various <i>Flood Insurance Manual</i> sections and appendices, intended to guide how NFIP insurers communicate with policyholders around specific topics or types of transactions	I. Underwriting-Related Policyholder Communications II. Declarations Page III. Replacement Cost Value Update Notices IV. Severe Repetitive Loss Property Notices V. FIRA Notice VI. Leased Federal Property Notice VII. Provisional Rating Notice VIII. Renewal Notice, Renewal Notice (This Is Not A Bill), and Final Notice IX. Cancellation Verification Letter

Table 2. Organization of the NFIP Flood Insurance Manual *continued*

TITLE	DESCRIPTION	HIGH-LEVEL CONTENT
Appendix J: Sample Scenarios	Provides application scenarios for NFIP insurance	I. Sample Scenarios
Appendix K: Documentation Requirements	Provides underwriting documentation requirements in a single place for easy reference	
Appendix L: Definitions and Acronyms	Definitions of specific NFIP terms and frequently used acronyms	I. Definitions II. Acronyms

IV. NFIP Resources

A. Policy-Specific Inquiries

Questions and requests for technical assistance regarding specific flood insurance policies and NFIP rules should generally follow the flow shown in **Figure 2** below.

Figure 2. How to Seek NFIP Technical Assistance

Policyholders who have questions about their policy should first contact their flood insurance agent. If the agent is unable to answer the question, they may direct it to the NFIP insurer (either a WYO company or the NFIP Direct) that issued the policy. The insurer may elevate complex questions to FEMA as needed.

B. General Assistance and Inquiries

For general assistance and inquiries (or for policy-specific issues after speaking with the agent or insurer), **contact the FEMA Mapping and Insurance eXchange (FMIX)**. The **FMIX** can answer general inquiries about mapping and flood insurance; call 1-877-336-2627 (1-877-FEMA-MAP) or visit https://www.floodmaps.fema.gov/fhm/fmx_main.html to access the chat and email functions.

If you need additional assistance regarding a flood insurance policy after **contacting FMIX** and **using the resources** listed in Table 3 below, contact FEMA's **Office of the Flood Insurance Advocate (OFIA)**. The OFIA advocates for the fair treatment of policyholders and property owners by providing education and guidance on all aspects of the NFIP, identifying trends affecting the public, and making recommendations for program improvements to FEMA leadership. Contact the OFIA by visiting <https://www.fema.gov/flood-insurance-advocate> and clicking on the "Ask the Advocate" button.

C. NFIP Topics and Contact Information

Table 3 provides links and contact information for various topics of interest to NFIP stakeholders.

Table 3. NFIP Topics and Contact Information

Topic	Mail and Website Address	Telephone
Agent Marketing, Selling, Servicing Information	https://agents.floodsmart.gov	N/A
Claims & Underwriting Forms	https://www.fema.gov/flood-insurance/find-form	N/A
Coastal Barrier Resources System (CBRS)	https://www.fws.gov/glossary/john-h-chafee-coastal-barrier-resources-system	N/A
Community Status Book	https://www.fema.gov/flood-insurance/work-with-nfip/community-status-book	N/A
FEMA Guidance	https://www.fema.gov/about/reports-and-data/guidance	N/A
Flood Maps and Related Products	FEMA Flood Map Service Center https://msc.fema.gov/portal/home	N/A
Flood Zone Determination Companies	https://nfipservices.floodsmart.gov/flood-zone-determination-companies	N/A
General Information for Agents & Consumers	https://www.floodsmart.gov	N/A
General Mapping and Flood Insurance Inquiries	FEMA Mapping and Insurance eXchange (FMIX) https://www.floodmaps.fema.gov/fhm/fmx_main.html FEMA-FMIX@fema.dhs.gov	Phone: 1-877-336-2627 (1-877-FEMA-MAP)
NFIP Regional Support Offices	https://nfipservices.floodsmart.gov/NFIP-Regional-Support-Offices	See link
Outreach Publications and Resources	https://www.fema.gov/flood-insurance/outreach-resources	N/A
NFIP Publications Order Form	https://agents.floodsmart.gov/puborderform	Phone: 1-800-480-2520
Training	https://nfipservices.floodsmart.gov/training	N/A
WYO Companies	https://nfipservices.floodsmart.gov/wyo-program-list	N/A